of Fiji's citizens of their legitimate rights. Gandhi also decided to suspend all trade and technical cooperation with Fiji.

'Never mind Fiji, such statements are impotent against military governments anywhere in the world,' said Shekhawat. 'The very concept of military rule is exploitative and it was merely a coincidence that Indians were at the receiving end in Fiji.'

The news of increasing atrocities against Indians rattled Gandhi's administration. Rajiv Gandhi issued a statement flagging human rights abuse in the Fiji islands. He said:

The South Pacific has long enjoyed a reputation for tranquility and friendship. It is unfortunate that this reputation has been tarnished by the military coup in Fiji. Different communities had lived together in Fiji in peace and harmony for more than a century. The special rights of the Melanesian Fijians were fully safeguarded. It is important to maintain racial amity. The current situation in Fiji is a matter of concern as it threatens human rights and human dignity. It is our hope that Parliamentary democracy will be restored in Fiji, promoting harmony and equality before the law for all it citizens.

'We were in the final stages of our planning when Rajiv Gandhi made this statement,' said Shekhawat. 'A special unit within the agency was created for the Fiji operation. The upper echelon of the government had given it complete operational freedom. It was composed of three fearless spies we fondly called "The Band of Three.'"

Mavericks and Avengers

On a chilly afternoon on 20 March 1988, thirty-five-year-old Anupam Malik checked into a R&AW safe house south of